

JesusOnline Equip

Ministry Resources Hub

Harvard Law Professor Puts Jesus' Resurrection on Trial

A free resource from JesusOnline Ministries.

Read or share online: app.jesusonline.com/post/51005-harvard-law-professor-puts-jesus-resurrection-on-trial

JesusOnline Equip · Ministry Resources Hub · equip.jesusonline.com

Free media and discipleship resources for pastors, leaders, and growing disciples.

Harvard Law Professor Puts Jesus' Resurrection on Trial

[Watch the video based on this article](#)

Legal scholar, Dr. Simon Greenleaf (1783–1853), decided to put Jesus' resurrection on trial by examining the evidence. Greenleaf helped to put the Harvard Law School on the map. He also wrote the three-volume legal masterpiece, *A Treatise on the Law of Evidence*, which has been called "the greatest single authority in the entire literature of legal procedure."¹ The U.S. judicial system today still relies on rules of evidence established by Greenleaf.

As a legal scholar, Greenleaf wondered if Jesus' resurrection would meet his stringent tests for evidence. He wondered whether or not the evidence for it would hold up in a court of law. Focusing his brilliant legal mind on the facts of history, Greenleaf began applying his rules of evidence to the case of Jesus' resurrection.

Contrary to what skeptics might have expected, the more Greenleaf investigated the record of history, the more evidence he discovered supporting the claim that Jesus had indeed risen from the tomb.

So, what was that evidence? Greenleaf observed several dramatic changes that took place shortly after Jesus died, the most baffling being the behavior of the disciples. It wasn't just one or two disciples who insisted Jesus had risen; it was all of them. Applying his own rules of evidence to the facts, Greenleaf arrived at his verdict.

After evaluating all the evidence, Greenleaf accepted Jesus' resurrection as the best explanation for the events that took place immediately after his crucifixion. To this brilliant legal scholar, it would have been impossible for the disciples to persist with their conviction that Jesus had risen if they hadn't actually seen the risen Christ.²

To this legal expert, the case for Jesus' resurrection was so compelling that he had no doubt it would hold up in a court of law. In his book, *The Testimony of the Evangelists*, Greenleaf documents the evidence supporting his conclusion. He challenges those who seek the truth about the resurrection to fairly examine the evidence.

Greenleaf believed that any unbiased person who honestly examines the evidence, as in a court of law, will conclude what he did—that Jesus Christ has truly risen.³

[Click here](#) to discover more of the evidence for Jesus' resurrection.

Endnotes

1. Knott, *The Dictionary of American Biography*, back cover of *The Testimony of the Evangelists*.
2. Simon Greenleaf, 1874. *The Testimony of the Evangelists*. New York, NY: 28.
3. Ibid. 46.

Thank you for downloading this free resource!

We're grateful you've taken this step in your spiritual journey. Your growth in Christ encourages us, and we pray this has been a blessing—strengthening your faith, deepening your understanding of God's Word, and equipping you to live for His glory.

Share Your Thoughts

Your feedback helps us improve future resources and encourages others:

Leave a Review or Send Us a Note — If you found this helpful, please consider leaving a short review. Your honest words make a big difference! We love hearing how God is using these materials in your life.

Share Your Story → equip.jesusunline.com/reviews/share

Discover More Free Resources

Continue growing in your walk with Jesus. Here are additional tools from the JO EQUIP library and JesusOnline Ministries:

- **Explore the Free Books** → equip.jesusunline.com/books
- **Download the Free JO App** — Your personal discipleship hub with the NET Bible, daily devotions, interactive studies, prayer tools, more books, and videos. [Download for Android](#) · [Download for iOS](#) · Explore in browser → app.jesusunline.com
- **Watch Video Playlists** → equip.jesusunline.com/playlists
- **Visit JesusOnline Ministries** — For more about this ministry and global outreach: jesusunlineministries.org

Would you like to help others? Share this resource (or the download link) with friends, your small group, or your church. Every copy planted can bear eternal fruit!

Thank you again for partnering with us in the Great Commission. May the Lord continue to fill you with joy, peace, and purpose as you walk with Him.

In Christ,

The JesusOnline Ministries Team

Apologetics • Evangelism • Discipleship • Equipping